Textual Practice

ISSN: 0950-236X (Print) 1470-1308 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rtpr20

The Sandcastle: 'investiture of freedom' in Levinas and disciplined freedom in Murdoch

S. P. Lee

To cite this article: S. P. Lee (02 Sep 2025): *The Sandcastle*: 'investiture of freedom' in Levinas and disciplined freedom in Murdoch, Textual Practice, DOI: 10.1080/0950236X.2025.2551334

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/0950236X.2025.2551334

Published online: 02 Sep 2025.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 55

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=rtpr20

TEXTUAL PRACTICE
https://doi.org/10.1080/0950236X.2025.2551334

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Check for updates

The Sandcastle: 'investiture of freedom' in Levinas and disciplined freedom in Murdoch

S. P. Lee

Department of English, Gyeongsang National University, Jinju, South Korea

ABSTRACT
In reading Iris Murdoch's novel, *The Sandcastle*, this essay explores a view of freedom that invites reflection on personal beliefs about permissible actions and constraints in a world that continual tests both agency and the values guiding its use. It considers moments where encounters with others prompt reconsideration of our entitlements and the freedom owed to them. Central to this analysis is Levinas' concept of freedom as an "investiture," suggesting that freedom is granted rather than innate. This idea resonates with Murdoch's characters, whose paradoxical qualities unsettle conventional assumptions about others. Murdoch' depiction of "disciplined" freedom parallels Levinas' notion of "created" freedom. In the novel, Nan reluctantly accepts her husband's aspirations for their family, while Rain's artistic pursuits gradually expands her understanding of freedom. Rain's eventual separation from Mor enables his return home, where he confronts his son Don's independent interests. Here, love emerges as inseparable from freedom. The essay highlights Murdoch's claim that quality art embodies an awareness of freedom as a way of seeing others, particularly when understood as disciplined or created. This convergence between Murdoch and Levinas enriches the reading of *The Sandcastle* and underpins the essay's overarching thesis.

ARTICLE HISTORY Received 22 May 2024; Accepted 6 June 2025

KEYWORDS Freedom; disciplined; investiture; art; knowing

Introduction

This paper aims to investigate the concept of freedom as delineated in Iris Murdoch's novel, *The Sandcastle*, specifically focusing on the notion of disciplined freedom, with close reference to Emmanuel Levinas' perspective of investitured freedom. The challenge to readers is to reconsider their assumptions regarding their entitlement to personal freedoms. It continuously poses the query: Have individuals genuinely earned the freedom they believe they are entitled to possess? This central question guides this paper's exploration,

CONTACT S. P. Lee splee139@gmail.com Department of English, Gyeongsang National University, Jinju Dae-Ro, 501. Jinju, South Korea

© 2025 Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

delving into the portrayal of freedom as a foundational aspect of existence within the framework of the novel's characters. In the process, the essay serves as a conduit for contemplating the practical manifestations of freedom in the contemporary era. By encouraging reflection on what individuals both relish and assert as self-attained freedom, the essay underscores the need to examine and reassess these notions critically. Consequently, this work provides a platform for unravelling the complexities of personal freedom, stimulating readers to assess their perceptions of autonomy and entitlement in the context of evolving societal dynamics.

Comparative readings of Murdoch and Levinas are both helpful and relevant to this paper's investigation of a shared theme: the idea of freedom as the overcoming of the totality of the ego. While general comparative studies of the two thinkers have proven fruitful over time, their perspectives on freedom remain underexplored.[1] Furthermore, applying this lens to a critical reading of *The Sandcastle* has yet to be attempted.

Over the past few decades, there have been proven comparative readings of Murdoch and Levinas within the same intellectual sphere. As early as 1996, David Tracy highlighted the need for such comparisons, stating that 'A critical comparison of the two thinkers on the "other" and "ethics" would be a valuable contribution' (56). Similarly, Maria Antonaccio acknowledges the parallels between their ideas: 'Murdoch's position bears some resemblance to the thought of Emmanuel Levinas' (Antonaccio 222). She further echoes Tracy by viewing their perspectives as a means to challenge the dominance of the self and transcend towards the other: 'Current forms of the ethics of alterity indebted to Emmanuel Levinas resist this trivialisation and lack of depth by insisting on an absolute obligation for the other. Murdoch's ethics does so through a retrieval of the idea of the Good' (289).

In 2002 and 2003 respectively, Fred Alford and Bob Plant expressed their views on how Murdoch and Levinas converge in their critique of the ego's totality. Alford explains that both thinkers regard the self as the adversary of the other and of authentic existence. Murdoch's concept of unselfing is presented as a means to transcend totality – the imposition of one's own categories and experiences onto the other.

> Levinas's world is one in which the self is the enemy not only of the other, but of authentic existence. Iris Murdoch shares this view with Levinas. Like Levinas, Murdoch sees the self as the enemy. 'Unselfing', as she calls it, is the means; the end is to overcome totality, which means the subjection of the other to my categories and my experience. (24)

Plant, in his critical reading of Alford's article, compares Levinas and Murdoch's perspectives on concepts such as responsibility to the other and the nature of the self. He observes that the totality of the self is overcome

through an ethical encounter with the other – a shattering experience that opens one to infinity – and through a responsibility for the other that disrupts self-interest. Levinas emphasises a radical break from the self and the world through such an ethical encounter, which opens a path to infinity and disrupts the self's totality. Murdoch, by contrast, seeks to transcend the limits of the self within the world of beings through a form of perfection achieved within the world (457).

Fiona Ellis offers a detailed exploration of the ethical and theological views of Iris Murdoch and Emmanuel Levinas. She observes that while both emphasise the significance of moral relations with others, they diverge on the role of God: Murdoch favours an impersonal Good, whereas Levinas sees God as present in our interactions with others. The article also examines the complexities of defining concepts such as Goodness, God, and humanity. Both thinkers agree that true humanity involves overcoming egoism ('fat relentless ego') and responding ethically to others, considering this ethical response essential to understanding what it means to be fully human. They assert that a genuine ethical relationship requires recognising the independent reality of the other person (64). In her reading of both figures, Ellis suggests a human effort to bring about this recognition of the particularity of others by 'standing on our own two feet and assuming responsibility for self and world' (83).

Stephen Bush, focusing on how attending to the particularity of others cultivates moral responsibility, notes that 'Murdoch agrees with Levinas on the need for practices of attention that undo our mastering tendencies' (170). This, in effect, aims to avoid what Levinas critiques as a 'totalising' attitude, where others are assimilated into one's own perspective. According to Bush, it is therefore significant that both Murdoch and Levinas 'place a priority on the need for moral attention to the particularity of the other' (173).

Bush also underscores the obstacle of living in fantasies of self and other, which Murdoch condemns. She insists that moral life requires overcoming the ego through disciplined attention, a point Bush illuminates by stating that 'morality requires a "disciplined overcoming of the self,"' quoting Murdoch (172). This disciplined attention aligns with the concept of 'unselfing', as Bush recalls, reminding us that it involves becoming 'aware that value exists that is independent of one's self' (172). This process entails moving beyond the totality of the self.[2] 'Unselfing' emerges as the outcome of these discussions, serving as a means thereof.

Taking these contextual bearings into account, this essay employs Levinas' interpretation of freedom – presented as investitured freedom – as a productive lens to interpret Murdoch's idea of disciplined freedom as a means of 'unselfing', which entails transcending the totality of the self in the reading of *The Sandcastle*.

Ideas of freedom in Murdoch and Levinas

Murdoch suggests in her article *Metaphysics and Ethics* that the definition of freedom should be based on a negative criticism. The negative criticism seems to lie, according to Murdoch, in the details of individual human situations rather than being a logical universality, which misrepresents 'the cloudy and shifting domain of the concepts by which men live – and these are subject to historical change' (75). What she has in mind when she criticises the self-indulgent understanding of freedom as 'freedom of overt choice' is the freedom to express differences: 'Our freedom is not just a freedom to choose and act differently, it is also a freedom to think and believe differently, to see the world differently, to see different configurations and describe them in different words' (72-73). Murdoch sees the redefinition of human freedom as the task of philosophy against a threatening framework of convention into which human beings are said to be cast, wherein freedom can be freely chosen.

Murdoch's view of this task is well reflected in Levinas' quest for the idea of freedom when he questions the foundation of freedom and takes a critical view of the current idea of freedom. What Levinas and Murdoch share when they examine the notion of freedom is the interest in considering the function of knowledge as being a vehicle to reach reality. In so doing, they appear to follow a similar trajectory to that suggested by Plato when he argues in *The Republic* that 'since the natural field of knowledge is reality – its function is to know reality as reality'(477b) Murdoch makes this evident by saying that 'freedom, itself a moral concept and not just a prerequisite of morality, cannot here be separated from the idea of knowledge' (to which goodness is connected). Goodness is 'a patient and just discernment and exploration of what confronts one, which is the result not simply of opening one's eyes but of a certainly perfectly familiar kind of moral discipline' (*The Idea of Perfection*, 330) This can be 'the realism of compassion', which she mentions elsewhere (*On 'God' and 'Good'*, 354.), and this must be arrived at by a negative criticism of freedom in order to reach the otherness of others.

Levinas, through the sense of knowledge and of negative criticism, places his understanding of knowing, presumably derived from Plato's, by positing the over-assertive aspects of freedom: he writes about a domineering idea of freedom, and he suggests that freedom should be *finite* in order to accommodate the issues of individuality, diversity, differences and change. According to him, and Murdoch would agree, the idea of freedom has been empowered on the basis of the idea of spontaneity with its arbitrariness. This is where he posits a great regression which amounts to questioning the legitimacy of the foundation of freedom. The regression is a reminder of the dangers of what can be called the spontaneous element of freedom: 'It is a shame freedom has of itself, discovering itself to be murderous and usurpatory in its very

exercise' (Levinas, 58: 1987). In this process of discovering what freedom actually does, Levinas, like Murdoch, seems to use the idea of knowledge and what Murdoch terms the negative criticism which leads to the recognition of the other: 'The knowing whose essence is critique cannot be reduced to objective cognition; it leads to the Other. To welcome the Other is to put in question my freedom' (Levinas, 85, *Totality and Infinity*). What both Levinas and Murdoch try to expound in their common question about the exercise of freedom are the ideas of finite freedom and disciplined freedom. This paper considers how these ideas of freedom work in *The Sandcastle*.

Bledyard's understanding of freedom, rooted in self-disciplined freedom

In *The Sandcastle*[3], there is an undercurrent truth about self-disciplined freedom. Bledyard (a Murdochian voice, according to Dipple, 15–17[4]), an art teacher, expounds this idea of freedom, and Mor (a schoolmaster) is practically led to expound the same idea; and a painter, Miss Rain Carter, motivated by Bledyard, illuminates a different mode of being in terms of a relationship in which Mor is involved. Nan, the wife of Mor, by contrast, coerces her husband and interferes with his plan to become a Member of Parliament (MP) and his dream for his children; she also deliberately attempts to alter her husband's consciousness to conform to her values.

Most people's personal values have a solipsistic basis, according to Murdoch, in favour of chasing one's own ontological identity and maintaining self. Bolton, in her analysis of Iris Murdoch's *Metaphysics as a Guide to Morals*, notably underscores Murdoch's interrogation of the nexus between freedom and happiness; 'she challenges the connection between freedom and happiness, always acutely aware of the threat of the totalitarian state who would deny human variety 'and the rights which *the fact* of variety carries' (218). Murdoch's stance is discernibly animated by an acute awareness of the potential encroachment posed by totalitarian regimes, which could undermine the rich tapestry of human diversity and the attendant entitlements intrinsic to such diversity. This perspective foregrounds a pivotal manifestation of freedom in its conventional connotation, one that manifests as the inclination of individuals to establish a coherent foundation amidst the variegated demands emanating from societal forces. Whether there is freedom in a society and therefore variety, or no freedom as a result of totalitarian denial of variety, one must manifest their personal values and thus achieve their happiness in spite of societal forces, whether there is one force or many. Therefore, corporate freedom does not necessarily beget individual agency and consequently does not guarantee happiness. It then follows that it is a self-indulgent danger to pursue freedom as a means of

attaining happiness in and of itself; what agency exists must be employed in view of the other and in the pursuit of Good, as one's agency presents a societal force exerted upon the freedom of the other. One's own happiness cannot be paramount (as in a totalitarian state); one must rather recognise that individual freedoms are intertwined.

The first instance of Nan's coercion of Mor's freedom arises from an argument about their children's future. Nan asserts that Mor's determination to enhance the children's social standing is a manifestation of the misleading urge to rationalise his aspiration to become an MP – a surrogate longing, as interpreted by her. Nan spent an unusual childhood in France: 'She (Nan) led quite a cloistered life with her father' (*The Sandcastle,* 11),[5] and, now in an isolated town, she develops a habit of mockery to preserve what she believes: 'He (Mor) had once imagined that she mocked others merely in order to protect herself' (10). This insulated outlook leads her to believe that her daughter's (Felicity's) possible future occupation as a typist is quite reasonable, while Mor argues that Felicity should have a secretary of her own: 'I don't want her to be secretary to some interesting man … I want her to be an interesting woman and have someone else be her secretary' (12). Furthermore, the fact that their son, Donald, is attending a junior school to sit for a Cambridge college entrance examination in chemistry irritates Nan since she is dubious about her children's ability and rebukes Mor's illusion: 'You live in a dream world, Bill. Neither of your children are clever, and you've already caused them both enough unhappiness by pretending that they are. You've bullied Don into taking the college exam and you ought to be satisfied with that' (12).

It might be said that freedom is the power of an individual to maintain his or her own particular values in order to secure his or her identity, but, in this novel, the term 'power' is much too strong. This means a domineering or coercing sense of freedom. This notion of freedom is expressed by disregarding others, as illustrated by the case of Nan; she, in the denial of knowledge, pursues the fulfilment of her own self at the expense of the other. Mor finds himself confined within the confines of his mental constructs, resulting in a degree of instability. But Murdochian freedom is closely related to morality. Her sense of freedom is that of moral freedom: 'Freedom is exercised in the confrontation by each other, in the context of an infinitely extensible work of imaginative understanding, of two irreducibly dissimilar individuals' (*The Sublime and the Good*, 216). Similarly, Levinas' idea of freedom is also centred on sociality, in which, according to him, the interpersonal relationship involves a radical responsibility for the other that precedes thought and freedom. Nan tries to reduce her husband and her children, in a way, to the sameness of knowledge.[6] Although there are many parts to reality – those of the many others – she disregards them and instead projects her internal knowledge outwards, imposing it on the other. She might be the one who,

as Murdoch says, is left 'with far too shallow and flimsy an idea of human personality' (*Against Dryness*, 287).

She is far from understanding what Murdoch terms 'the opacity of persons' and 'the volcanic otherness of people'. She just stays where she would like to be without relating to other ideas; therefore, she loses all sense of the outside world. She presents Mor with a space in which he cannot fully make himself comfortable. When they bicker, Mor finds that 'her strength is endless', and it is Mor who says 'sorry': 'He made it a rule to apologise, whether or not he thought himself in the wrong' (11).

Nan's enlightenment occurs when she realises that her husband is able to do what she never expected him to: she finds Mor is in love with a young artist, Rain Carter, who is painting a portrait of the retired headmaster of the school where Mor is teaching. Rain is consistently presented in deliberate contrast to Nan in the novel. She spent her childhood with her father in the south of France, and she remembers her childhood as 'a time of terrible dryness' (72) when her father was a solitary person (73). But she is totally different from Nan. As Mor says,

> His thoughts switched to Miss Carter, who had been responsible for his ability to decide, having given him, by her mere existence, a fresh sense of power and possibility. Mor mused for a while upon this mystery. Eccentric people, he concluded, were good for conventional people, simply because they made them able to conceive of everything being quite different. This gave them a sense of freedom. Nothing is more educational, in the end, than the mode of being of other people (67).

Rain is particularly sensible and stimulates Mor's latent energy. She is seen as one who animates Mor and makes him feel happy even about petty things. On his way to a luncheon party where he will see Rain, he experiences the bliss of existence: 'As Mor free-wheeled through the trees, his bicycle bumping about agreeably on the undulating track, he experienced a profound sense of well-being and general benevolence' (67). When Mor realises he is in love with Rain, he sees things differently: 'Mor drew in a deep breath and smiled down at the dry earth below him, swaying slightly on his heels … He caressed the wood of the gate. It was dry flaky wood, warm in the sun, beautiful. He could not stop smiling. I must be mad' (149). This feeling of well-being amounts to saying, 'You've made me exist for the first time. I began to be when I loved you; I saw the world for the first time, the beautiful world full of things and animals that I'd never seen before' (301). This enlivening experience of blissful happiness is in contrast to his life with Nan: 'It was simply the non-existence in his life, as it solidly and in reality was, of any place for an emotion or a drama of this kind' (160). Rain is sensitive to what Mor feels. On a school tour, Mor sees with annoyance that Rain is wearing trousers. Rain notices through his awkwardness that he seems distracted by

her wearing trousers and says, 'I can see that you are irritated by my trousers … If I had thought more I would not have worn them' (44). Asked to see the school chapel, Rain refuses by saying, 'Not dressed like this. I might offend someone' (47). This is part of her perceptiveness – considering other people's feelings – and this disposition prevents possible disapproval by others.

Rain Carter's perceptive freedom as an artist

For the purpose of reading this novel from the perspective of freedom as a notion of existence, the case of Rain Carter deserves close attention. It can be argued that she embodies ideas that are inseparable from what Murdoch and Levinas seek in their whole view of life. As an artist, Rain explores a multiplicity of phenomena of human reality which lie in the shifting horizon of self-determining consciousness. She insists that her creative endeavour depends largely on understanding this mental part of human experience, and that through her artistic medium, a comprehensive awareness of individual events can be expressed. She stands for Murdoch's hostility to the Human tradition of mathematical logic and science, from which 'we derive the idea that reality is finally a quantity of material atoms and that significant discourse must relate itself directly and indirectly to reality so conceived' (*Against Dryness*, 287–8). Rain attempts to discover a quality of vitality lurking in a dialogue in terms of not only the present, but also the past, of a person:

> You (Mor) must tell me all about Mr Demoyte … everything, as much as you know. As you will realise, painting a portrait is not just a matter of sitting down and painting what you see. Where the human face is concerned, we interpret what we see more immediately and more profoundly than with any other object. A person looks different when we know him – he may even look different as soon as we know one particular thing about him. And in any case there are simpler problems. A choice must be made about the clothes which the person is to wear in the picture, the posture which he is to hold, the expression on his face, the background, the accessories. A consideration of all these things will then affect one's methods and one's technique. It is impossible to be in a hurry … I am employed to paint *your* Mr Demoyte, not *my* Demoyte … I want to paint a really good likeness. We all think that there is something which is what a person is really like, and that this takes some time to learn. (45, 46)

Her sense that gives a space of freedom that allows others to be what they are really like. This is the same sense of freedom this paper explores. Rain seems suitable for the role she is given.

When Rain is first seen looking at a rug in Demoyte's house, she reveals her intention of looking at things holistically, as when she investigates the rug, and she recognises the blurred boundary of shade and surface shown

on it: 'Do you notice how mysteriously the colours behave here? Each piece has its own shade, and then there is a sort of surface colour which the whole rug has which is different, a sort of blush' (27). This passage suggests her awareness of encountering a factor underlying the different modes of existence and, more clearly, when something harmonious is discerned, her essential share of the artistic quest is to make a space where artistic otherness may exist. This is what Murdoch calls the experience of freedom boosted by imagination in order to see something beyond: 'Imagination … is the ability to see the other things … nature, reality, the world … Imagination is a kind of freedom, a renewed ability to perceive and express the truth' (*Art is the Imagination of Nature*, 255). Her capacity to discern things in such a way as to pick up the artistic quality of the colours on the rug relates her to Murdoch's idea of the sublime later in this novel.

Murdoch, in one of her essays written a few years before this novel, discusses the complicated difficulties involved in describing mental events in relation to thoughts. This is related to Rain's attempt to portray the whole person existing behind the two-dimensional surface of a face. This can be a *metaphysical* quest. In the article, Murdoch states, 'Sometimes, thoughts are queer phenomena and we find it hard to offer a clear and unambiguous description as with other kinds of queer phenomena. A mental event, as an experience, is not connected with 'meaning' in a way which is different from that in which any other experience may be connected with meaning … If a thought is ever an experience, the experience may be more or less sharp and clear, and may be described thus or thus according to our interests and purposes' (*Nostalgia for the Particular*, 50–51). Rain is sharply against the idea of behaviourism (which Murdoch also criticises), based on an effectively materialistic theory expressed as 'a dramatic view of the individual as a solitary will'. As Murdoch explains, 'My inner life, for me just as for another, is identifiable as existing only through the application to it of public concepts, concepts which can only be constructed on the basis of *overt* behaviour' (italics added, *Against Dryness*, 288). Rain is seeking the private realm of a person, where she can see something obscure beyond the public arena. This communal area, according to Murdoch, hardly penetrates to the inner life. Murdoch relates this personal region to mental events and thought as a kind of experience which is unique and defies comprehension by language. As Murdoch continues her quest for mental experience, she remarks that physical phenomena do not fully explain inner feeling. She goes on to say that all experiences are 'private' (*Nostalgia for the Particular*, 49), and 'the definition of experience does not depend on language' (*Nostalgia for the Particular*, 58). Rain, likewise, strives to represent that which is beyond language. So, she insists that she needs to know what Demoyte *is*, not what Demoyte *looks like*: 'A person looks different when we know him' (45). To Mor, Rain seems a real person, as does Bledyard (72).

Bledyard's challenge to rain's view on art and freedom

It is Bledyard who challenges Rain's view of art. He is a man who disregards convention (72), as does Rain (67). Rain knows him from the first: 'I look forward to meeting him … I have seen some of his work. It is good … I have seen at least three good landscapes. But I gather now he has theories which interfere with his painting?' (30). It can be said that Murdoch presents Bledyard as one who enlightens and enhances Rain's idea of art, yet she describes Rain becoming perturbed when Bledyard takes an interest in her. She finds him fascinating at a tea party where Bledyard demonstrates his view of art while he struggles to overcome an impediment in his speech:

> Representation is an ambiguous word … to represent something something is a task which must be undertaken with humility. What is the first and most fundamental truth which an incarnate being must realise? That he is a thing, a material object in space and time, and that as such he will come to an end. What is the next next truth which he must realise? That he is related on the one hand to God, who is not a thing, and on the other hand to other things which surround him. Now these other things things … are some of them mere things, and others of them God-related things like himself. (75)

He goes on to maintain the difference between dealing with human and other things in art:

> We find it natural to make the distinction. Only we do not make it absolutely absolutely enough. When confronted with an object which is not a human being we must of course treat it reverently. We must, if we paint it, attempt to show what it is like in itself, and not treat it as a symbol of our own moods and wishes. The great painter the great painter is he who is humble enough in the presence of the object to attempt *merely* to show what the object is like. But this *merely*, in painting, is everything … Pictures of Our Lord usually affect us by the majesty of the conception, and not by any particular expression or gesture. Where the picture is individualised, as in Caravaggio's rendering of Christ at Emmaus, we are shocked. We should be equally shocked at any representation of a human face. (76–78)[7]

This demonstration reflects Murdoch's urge to argue, as she does in her essay, *The Fire and the Sun*, that 'it is art in which the artist has surrendered "his personal will to the rhythm of divine thought"'. According to Murdoch, this surrendering can be achieved by refraining from apprehending things merely by subjective understanding, by leaving them as they are and considering their existence beyond visibility and accepting the boundaries of things and their shadows.[8]

At Bledyard's remarks on portrait painting, Rain feels angry and disturbed.[9] The feeling, however, does not make her dejected. When the painting is almost finished, Mor's appreciation of it explains what Rain has had in mind: Mor felt that he was really seeing Demoyte for the first time, and with this, a sudden compassion came over him. 'It was indeed the face of an old

man. In spite of the bright colours of the rug, the picture as a whole was sombre. The sky was pale, with a flat melancholy pallor, and the trees outside the window were bunched into a dark and slightly menacing mass' (168). Murdoch explicitly leads her readers to see what expression the picture shows in terms of the 'head': 'From the extremely decorative background Demoyte's head emerged with enormous force. The face was in repose, the curve of the lips expressing a sort of fastidious thoughtfulness rather than the sarcasm which was his more customary expression … the features were meticulously represented, the innumerable wrinkles, the bright slightly bleary eye of the old man, the tufts of hair in the ears and nostrils' (168). This is not what Mor has known about Demoyte: 'He (Demoyte) must look like that when he is alone … it must be so. I would never have known that' (168). The novel sets Mor as a person very close to Demoyte; he may be the only one who can explain what he is, apart from Miss Handforth, Demoyte's spinster housekeeper. In considering this, it can be said that what Mor sees in the picture represents a truer interpretation of his appearance. Bledyard seems to view this as problematic:

> Miss Carter, this is an interesting picture, it is nearly a good picture … But you have made your picture too beautiful … it is a question of the head head, Miss Carter. You have chosen to present it as a series of definitions, well executed in themselves, I don't deny. But as it is its strength its strength depends upon the power of these definitions to appeal to a conception of character in the observer. One result of this is that while your sitter looks old he does not look *mortal*. It is the mass of the head that ought to impress us if the picture is to have the power of a masterpiece. The head should be seen as a coinherence coinherence of masses. The observation of character is very well. But this is a *painting*, Miss Carter. (169–70)

The main effect of reading this novel may be that one sees how Rain gains a deeply enhanced understanding of art. Rain has the capacity to perceive Bledyard's enigmatic comment on art. The idea of freedom presented in this book is the vehicle through which Rain is led to consummate her standpoint on painting when she becomes aware of the precept of freedom. What, then, is the notion of freedom Murdoch displays? For Levinas, freedom is *created*, not absolute, which means that this sense of freedom is concerned for the existence of others. Murdoch elsewhere seems to support this view: 'Freedom … is the disciplined overcoming of self' (*The Sovereignty of Good over Other Concept*, 378). Mor's speech seems to be relevant in assuming that freedom is grace and self-discipline. Mor inflects this theme of freedom: 'Freedom … is not exactly what I would call a virtue. Freedom might be called a benefit or a sort of grace – though of course to seek it or to gain it might be a proof of merit' (53). 'Let me try again. You say surely freedom is a virtue – and I hesitate to accept this phrase. Let me explain why. To begin with, as I was saying in my talk this evening, freedom

needs to be defined. If by freedom we mean absence of external restraint, then we may call a man lucky for being free – but why should we call him good? On the other hand, if by freedom we mean self-discipline, which dominates selfish desires, then indeed we may call a free man virtuous' (54). And this statement coincides with Bledyard's: 'Real freedom is a total absence of concern about yourself' (213–14). But when Bledyard asserts his idea of freedom, Mor paradoxically does not fully understand what it means to him. He is desperately concerned about his happiness. Bledyard continues, 'You know you are damaging her [Rain]. You are diminishing her by involving her in this. A painter can only paint what he is. You will prevent her from being a great painter … she is young, her life is only beginning, she will have many things' (214).

It is Rain, undoubtedly, who understands this statement; when she reworks the head in the picture, she makes plain that *she* is ruining Mor and his family: 'I had just not realised that I was wrecking your whole life. I see it all quite differently now. I see your children, I see your ambitions. You love me, yes. But you wouldn't really forgive me for having deprived you of so much. And I would not forgive myself for doing so' (300). She realises the notion of freedom that this novel reveals, and this may be the freedom that Murdoch describes in an essay written two years later than this novel: 'Freedom is exercised in the confrontation by each other, in the context of an infinitely extensible work of imaginative understanding, of two irreducibly dissimilar individuals' (*The Sublime and the Good*, 216). Rain is sensitive enough to convey the notion of freedom, but it needs to be embodied more practically in that so far, she has a mainly theoretical sense of freedom. As Bledyard points out with reference to her painting: 'You have chosen to present it as a series of definitions, well executed in themselves, I don't deny' (169). She describes Demoyte's picture as a 'really good likeness' (46) and is not able to move beyond her own understanding. She still stays within her experience when she draws him: 'Perhaps it is rather that we *feel* our own face, as a three-dimensional mass, from within – and when we try in a painting to realise what another person's *face* is, we come back to the experience of our own' (107).[10] This passage indicates exactly the attitude with which Rain has been painting, and it reflects the problem Bledyard raised earlier: 'When we look upon a human face, we interpret it by what we are ourselves' (77). This might mean that Rain still tends to present her painting as shallow, as is the vividness of the real face itself. This cannot be by any means the dynamic expression of a person. The struggling quest to realise what painting is, however, becomes enlivened when Rain understands, through Nan's speech, the value of Mor's concealed desire to be an MP: 'The dear wish and ambition of my husband, myself, and our children that he should serve his country in the highest role to which a democratic society can call

its citizens – that of a Member of Parliament' (193). Rain apprehends that she has disregarded Nan and her family, and especially Mor, to whom she says, 'If we were together my work would continue. But what about yours? Would it in the end satisfy you just to be with me?' (300). And she goes on to say, 'I saw it all so simply, with nothing to it but you leaving your wife whom you didn't love and who didn't love you. But a life has so much more in it than that' (301). The idea of freedom Murdoch puts forward in this novel is a sort of self-disciplined one: according to Murdoch, freedom involves considering something or someone away from one's solipsistic understanding. She expresses this through Bledyard, within a dependence of life which contains a sense of freedom directed not only towards personal happiness but towards the other based on a stable ego: 'In all this you consider only yourself … But look rather upon the others – and make yourself nothing in your awareness of them … You live in a world of imagined things. But if you were to concern yourself truly with others and lay yourself open to any hurt that might come to you, you would be enriched in a way of which you cannot now even conceive' (213). It may be argued that this is a functional conception of freedom which invites a person to a shared-personal identity – a continued or synthetic identity produced by an inward understanding of self and the other given the idea of freedom that it is not something you earn but something that is given and demanding. Levinas argues that freedom is not discretionary but obligatory (*Totality and Infinity*, 84). Rain's adaptation of her attitude to fit an assumption of the need to reach others shows how the action of self-disciplined freedom can exist and how it is born from the 'negative criticism' of freedom discussed above. In this context, Levinas' idea of freedom – associated with responsibility to others – emerges. He relates it to his suggestion of finite freedom when he challenges the failure of the I's spontaneity: 'This finite freedom is not primary, is not initial; but it lies in an infinite responsibility where the other is not other because he strikes up against and limits my freedom, but where he can accuse me to the point of persecution, because the other, absolute other, is another one (*autrui*)'.[11] This self-disciplined freedom, which Murdoch relates to the recognition of duty by freedom (*The Sovereignty of Good over Other Concepts*, 367), is illustrated by the fact that Rain is equipped with the flair to notice the unmarked surface of the rug in Demoyte's living room as part of her aesthetic appreciation. This highlights the idea of freedom by letting Rain modify the painting in an act of reaching for a closer encounter with the truth – with knowledge – whatever it may be. In doing so, freedom as a reinterpretation of the path to the sublime slips into the story in order to integrate several concepts of freedom.

Rain, responding to the claims of the other-seeking idea of freedom, is now aware of what her painting should be, and of course there is a *loss*, a

real sacrifice, in the re-handling of the painting. The following passage shows how she becomes enlightened:

> Rain had changed the head a great deal. At first sight it seemed as if she had spoilt it. The fine sensitive lines which had built up the quiet musing expression which Mor had liked so much had been covered over with layer after layer of tiny patches of paint. The head stood out now solider, uglier, the expression no longer conveyed by the fine details, but seeming to emerge from the deep structure of the face. (309)

Her understanding of art now appears to be balanced by a complementary sense of the significance of having a deep awareness of the whole person. Her alteration of the painting seems to be based on the impact of the displacement of her own way of seeing and thinking about the portrait. It appears that she now looks at the assemblage of the hidden configurations of the face; there is the quality of a naked face deep under the surface. She may feel a movement between her own naked face and the face in the picture – a connection to recognise the existence of an otherness which is the purely Levinasian element of a face: an awe-inspiring acceptance of others. It may be that Murdoch enhances the adumbration by implying multiple dimensions in the comprehension of art as she writes about the difficulty of describing a particular experience: 'If the notion of the self-describing particular cannot be defended in length, then perhaps it can be defended in depth … consider our enjoyment of the "language" of a Persian rug [which Rain enjoys looking into]. Here there is not the thin light touch of recognition but a deep gazing. (Gazing is here the master image.) Here too we can refine our experience, making it more and more specific, seeing more and more deeply into the sense which is before us' (*Nostalgia for the Particular*, 54). Rain's rejection of Mor reveals that perhaps she is the only one in the novel caught between two outside demands on her: her art and Mor. She has the opportunity to make a choice outside any intended pull – and does so by looking at other people outside the *égoisme àdeux* of herself and Mor. The changes in Rain's view wrought by her increasing involvement with tormenting decisions expand her perception of freedom. This perception is embodied in Murdoch's argument on the sublime in relation to freedom: 'The sublime is an experience of the imagination and the reason in conflict. Whereas the beautiful reposes us, the sublime rends us … since reason is the moral will, the experience of the sublime is a sort of moral experience, that is, an experience of freedom' (*The Sublime and The Beautiful Revisited*, 263). Through Rain's deep gaze into reality, she *practically* achieves an understanding that there exists an inner dimensional sphere of a person. Freedom, in this sense, linked with responsibility is 'an elevation and inspiration without complacency', according to Levinas.[12] This is well expressed in Rain's corrected portrait of Demoyte. The painting

serves to illuminate Mor's desperate search for his freedom; a freedom that resists the self-denying imposition of Nan's own internal world upon his actions and a freedom to live with the other whilst preserving the self of the other. Consequently, it encourages him to shift from his unceasing desire for Rain.

Mor's journey towards acquiring a different sense of freedom

Mor abruptly returns to his normal life: 'I suppose I ought to go back … Nan will be wondering where I am' (309). The novel presents his sudden changes in attitude as a revelation: 'He said this without thought, automatically' (309). He refuses Demoyte's suggestion to take the picture that Rain has drawn of him: 'No … you keep it for me. I should like it to be here' (309). His undulating journey weighs against his own happiness and that of Rain and Nan, and ends by considering other people; this is an ethical act of freedom that Levinas endorses. It is a knowing of others that does not involve thematisation but 'leads back to the relation with the Other, that is, to justice' (*Totality and Infinity*, 89), where, Levinas asserts, freedom 'begins with conscience, to which the other is presented as the Other, and where the movement of thematisation is inverted' (*Totality and Infinity*, 86). So something strange happens; Nan learns to consider her husband, and Rain realises Mor's other desire to be an MP; also, Mor understands that his son's (Don's) way of life is different from what he had wished it to be. It is intriguing that Murdoch makes Rain and Don overlap; on his way home, Felicity runs up to him, calling a name which he understands as 'Rain's come back!' – but she actually says, 'Don's come back!' (310). Mor loses Rain but gains a different Don, as implied by Felicity: 'Do you think Don could work with Tim Burke now? … He'd much rather do that than chemistry … Only he was always afraid to tell you'. And Mor agrees: 'Perhaps it may be the best thing. But we'll see' (311). He is becoming ready to embrace the idea of freedom. In this sense, the recurrent figure of the tower, presented as the central symbol in the novel, is a manoeuvre stimulating the plot in order to illuminate the notion of freedom.

As this essay points out, the novel argues that 'real freedom is a total absence of concern about yourself' (213–14), and the discourse around this notion is given illustration in the symbol of the tower. Rain chooses a tower as Demoyte's symbol for the background of the portrait, depicting his academically oriented attitude to improving the school's grades when he was a headmaster. The way he executed his job had been like a 'reign of terror'. He had shown his propensity for 'star' pupils and had been fond of proficiency in work. In terms of morality, we are told: 'Demoyte took the view that if a boy could look after his Latin prose his character would look after itself' (20). His only concern was to change the school

ranking: the true needs of school staff and of the pupils counted for less: 'If the quality of an individual's teaching declined, that individual would shortly find that Demoyte was anxious for his departure' (19). Mor's wishes for Don are similar, as although he is aware of Don's lacklustre academic ability, as he says to Rain: 'My son isn't a scholar' (47), he pushes his son to take the Cambridge exam in chemistry. In fact, Don is a cinephile and enormously interested in books on climbing and adventure, and in Tim Burke's craft. It can thus be said that if the idea of freedom in this novel is an idea of other-centric behaviour, the tower symbolises the self-seeking attitude, and Murdoch authorises such an idea (of limiting one's overriding greediness) in various ways. In Felicity's tarot game, which she plays because she anxiously wants to know or predict what the secret affair between her father, Mor, and Rain involves, the tower is presented as a *broken* one – as it is in the tarot pack[13] – which separates her father and Miss Carter, according to her own arbitrary interpretation, and she sees this as an auspicious omen (221). The broken tower suggests the falling of self-seeking desire. During a lecture by Bledyard on art, Don and his friend Carde are found climbing the forbidden tower, disturbing Bledyard's lecture by creating turmoil among the pupils. They are immediately expelled from the school, and Don misses the chemistry exam when he runs away. This leads Mor to feel the disastrousness of his self-seeking ambition for his son – the disastrousness of climbing the forbidden tower – and it happens that Rain eventually rethinks her painting.

Murdoch presents Bledyard as an odd person, with his stammering way of speaking, which creates hysterical laughter in the class. Through this description, even though he offers a deep and strong idea of art and comes across as a real person, he seems to be devalued. Why does Murdoch present him in this way? It is perhaps because his thought mainly lies in theory and not in practice. Too much theory obstructs his work of painting, as Rain notices: 'I gather he has theories which interfere with his painting?' (30). He remains a prophetic figure without considering the complicated reality of life. This seems to be clear when he scorns Mor for his unacceptable relationship with Rain. His argument is cogent and gives expression to what Murdoch wishes to say through him. His debate on the idea of freedom is not very much different from that of Mor. But, just as his notion of freedom stresses self-discipline and consideration for others, Mor nevertheless argues the importance of the happiness and freedom produced in his relationship with Rain. So Bledyard fails to recognise Mor as other when he points out to Mor that 'but in all this you consider only yourself. You do not truly apprehend the distinct being of either your wife or Miss Carter … look rather upon the others – and make yourself nothing in your awareness of them' (213). Bledyard's argument hinges exclusively on the external aspects of what lies beyond his immediate perception; he seems to ignore

the harassment Mor has been suffering in his marriage. We are told about his faithfulness in marriage that 'it was simply the non-existence in his life … of any place for an emotion or drama of this kind' (160). Nan, with her 'insulated serenity and superiority', depresses Mor. But when he feels in love with Rain, he realises that he is 'so moved and softened and a man in a dream' (159, 160). It is Rain who recognises Mor's prudence and vitality. Bledyard disregards this aspect and just speaks about truth according to his own self. So, it can be said that just as Mor has been mocked by his wife so Bledyard is also an object of mockery on account of his hypocrisy, which highlights the calamity of his most important annual lecture on art – when Don and Carde climb the tower. The tower therefore provides the image of a calamitous self-centred attitude and of a doomed unbalanced view of human understanding.

But Murdoch presents Bledyard's idea as relevant: 'If you were to concern yourself truly with others and lay yourself open to any hurt that might come to you, you would be enriched in a way of which you cannot now even conceive' (213). Mor, Nan and Rain are all enlightened (or are forced to be enlightened), and are thus put in their places. That Felicity feels at ease when she notices that everything has returned to normal (she says, 'everything was all right now' [313]) points to the epitome of Murdoch's achievement, which integrates ontological deflections into an all-embracing and all-comprehending credo about human understanding. In doing so, Murdoch shows an enhanced understanding of the complexity of human natures – all different and all dissimilar, indefinable and to which Levinas' understanding of freedom takes its path in as much as complexity is acknowledged and made known – the human understanding Murdoch and Levinas share. Levinas argues in this regard that 'to welcome the Other is to put in question my freedom' (*Totality and Infinity*. 85). Having my freedom challenged, I discern my knowing of the existence of others' particularity and overcome 'the arbitrariness of freedom' (*Totality and Infinity*. 85). Levinas carries on, saying that 'the knowing whose essence is critique cannot be reduced to objective cognition; it leads to the Other'. Being taken to Don's particular needs, Mor seems to understand 'the investiture that liberates freedom from the arbitrary' (84–85).

When Don flees and seeks refuge in Tim Burke's shop, he becomes intrigued by the art of the goldsmith. This stirs mixed emotions in Mor, creating a sense of unease, yet also prompting him to acknowledge the distinct talents of his son. Don remains the enigma that eludes Mor's understanding; he is a different and dissimilar person with his particular separateness or experiences – his own outlook. Murdoch writes in relation to this: 'The experiences now in question, rigid objects of contemplation, are vertebrates, their *structure* is inside them'('Nostalgia for the Particular', 55). This is not what Murdoch calls ordinary experiences but contemplative experiences in

which Mor shockingly has an encounter with somebody else. Mor now seems to understand that he is not able to designate his son as his wishes: 'We'll see about that … perhaps it may be the best thing. But we'll see' (311).

It should be noted, however, that there is a conflict of values at the end of the book. Demoyte thinks Mor is wrong not to go after Rain. Felicity feels a grief that she cannot account for. This does not seem to be resolved. Partly, this lack of resolution may derive from Murdoch's discreditable affair with Donald MacKinnon, as both Conradi and Wilson claim[14] – Bledyard is almost entirely based on MacKinnon in personality and in moral authority and doctrine, but it makes both the actual and the fictional affair reflect a conflict in Murdoch between the awareness of the other in the devastating blow of passionate but self-seeking love and the awareness of the other in the regard of a built-up complex structure (and perhaps this is also represented in the image of the tower).

Conclusion

The perspective on freedom examined in this essay has the potential to initiate contemplation about one's convictions regarding permissible actions and restrictions in a world plagued by challenges: challenges to one's agency and forces exerted via an interplay of agencies. That rumination precipitates that looking into others which challenges our entitlement to an arbitrary definition and exertion of freedom. This challenged freedom leaves one's entitlement in question and leads him to consider the entitlement of the other. The main point of using the idea of freedom in reading this novel is that freedom is an 'investiture' as Levinas terms it – it is created and given, not innate. One must be self-disciplined in order to depart from the self, resist the challenges of their environment and deliberate a selfless viewing of the other so as to provide for the freedom of the other, rather than inflict the calamitous violence of the proverbial tower. Such an idea of freedom points to an acknowledgement of the immeasurable and paradoxical entities of the characters in the novel as a means of overcoming the instinctive and assertive view of others. In this sense, Murdoch 's description of freedom as 'disciplined' coincides with Levinas' 'created' freedom. Nan comes to learn about her husband's reality and, though very reluctantly, she acknowledges his particular desire for himself and his children. Rain, who has an inborn sense of art, catches the sense of freedom gradually, and the idea accompanies her during her study of painting and her pronounced interest in Bledyard's exposition in the course of learning. She lets go of Mor, which, in turn, helps him to return home, where he has to cope with his son Don, whose interests do not align with his father's. Freedom is associated here with love – a dignifying and welcoming of the other. Murdoch seeks to show again that art, especially good art, as an

agent, suggests an understanding of freedom as a way of seeing others when the idea of freedom is properly founded as a disciplined or created freedom. Thus, as this paper has sought to show, the idea of freedom presented by Murdoch and Levinas clearly helps to support and enhance our reading of *The Sandcastle*.

Notes

1. Holland is the sole scholar who has most substantially examined Murdochian freedom as positive freedom, a concept she rephrases in her work; 'Positive freedom involves understanding the circumstances one confronts and knowing how to conduct oneself in a manner which is appropriately responsive. Such insight may be achieved as the result of willed effort (268) Margaret Holland, 'Social Convention and Neurosis as Obstacles to Moral Freedom', in Justin Broackes (ed.), Iris Murdoch (Philosopher-Oxford University Press, 2012), pp. 255–73.
2. An indirect comparative reading of Murdoch and Levinas can be approached through the works of Simone Weil and Martin Buber, who were frequently engaged by Rowan Williams and Gillian Rose as frameworks to explore their concerns with true humanity. Additionally, William Shakespeare provides a valuable lens through which to examine both Murdoch and Levinas in tandem. See Rowan Williams, 'The Necessary Non-Existence of God', in Richard Bell (ed.), *Simone Weil's Philosophy of Culture: Reading Towards a Divine Humanity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University, 1993). See Gillian Rose, *Judaism and Modernity: Philosophical Essays* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1993). See Emmanuel Levinas, *Time and The Other*, trans. Richard A. Cohen (Pittsburgh: Duquesne University Press, 1987). Both Williams and Rose extensively engaged with the works of Iris Murdoch and Emmanuel Levinas, though they never explicitly connected the two. Interestingly, John Bayley once informed me that Murdoch never mentioned Levinas at all.
3. Conradi views the theme of the novel as romance (2011: 70), while Dooley similarly interprets it, describing 'the focus of the novel as different kinds of love' (2009: 421, 422). Priscilla Martin and Anne Rowe also adopt a similar perspective, highlighting the plot's exploration of 'a vulnerable structure of married life' (37). Peter Conradi, *The Saint and Artist: A Study of the Fiction of Iris Murdoch* (Harper Collins, 2011). Gillian Dooley, 'Iris Murdoch's Novels of Male Adultery: The Sandcastle, An Unofficial Rose, The Sacred and Profane Love Machine, and The Message to the Planet', *English Studies*, 90.4 (2009), pp. 421–34. Priscilla Martin and Anne Rowe. *Iris Murdoch: A Literary Life* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2010).
4. Dipple, Elizabeth. *Iris Murdoch: Work for the Spirit* (London: Methuen, 1982).
5. Murdoch, *The Sandcastle* (London: Chiatto & Windus, 1957), 11. Subsequent references to this edition will be represented within the text parenthetically by page number.
6. Sameness is the Levinasian quality associated with I.
7. It can be argued that Levinas' deference for *face* is paralleled to Murdoch's consideration for the face in this quotation. Bledyard's emphasis on the face in Rain's portrait shows that every detail of the face carries the wholeness of a person emitting a quality of non-interpretability; one single part of a face

can refer the whole history of a person, which is otherwise unknowable. It is an awesome giving, as Bledyard wants to put it. In Levinas, it is a gateway to an understanding of otherness. This novel seems to lead Rain to this understanding.

8. Moden highlights the artistic sense of morality revealed in Rain and Bledyard, particularly in connection with Weinberger. This is expressed as their 'respect for the essential difference of individuals and their resulting acceptance of the inevitable imperfection of any portrait' (258) Rebecca Moden, *Iris Murdoch and Harry Weinberger Imaginations and Images* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2023).
9. 'But somehow it's just wrong, there's some colossal distortion … I'm really upset by that man … this man makes me feel that everything I do must be rotten' (81–82). It is interesting to note that Sessler quotes what Levinas writes in relation to what the Levinasian face does, particularly in regards to the subject of freedom: 'The face in which the other – the absolutely other – presents himself does not negate the same, does not do violence to it … It remains commensurate with him who welcomes. This presentation is pre-eminently non-violence, for instead of offending my freedom it calls it to responsibility and founds it … It is peace'. Tal Sessler, *Levinas and Camus. Humanisms of the Twenty-First Century* (London: Continuum, 2008), 34. Obviously, therefore, the face of the other brings a momentum to make my freedom subject to the other's care.
10. It can be said that Rain, when drawing someone else's face, experiences two naked faces: her own and the sitter's. Her three-dimensional facial experience reveals, and regretfully returns to, her own previous experience so that she is able to build a bridge to the otherness of others. This is purely Levinas' flavour.
11. Emmanuel Levinas, *The Levinas Reader* (ed.), Seán Hand (Oxford: Blackwell, 1998), 113. Elsewhere, Levinas makes a similar argument on this finite freedom: 'Finite freedom is not an infinite freedom, acting in a finite field and for that reason, limited. Yet it is the freedom of a "me" [*moi*], whose unlimited responsibility (not measured by freedom and irreducible to non-freedom) demands subjectivity as that which nothing and no one could replace, and strips this subjectivity bare like a passivity, like a self in an accusative form without a nominative … this freedom is finite because it is a relationship with another; it remains freedom, because this other is another person [*cet autre est autrui*]'. Emmanuel Levinas, *God, Death, and Time*, trans. Bettina Bergo (Stanford: Stanford University Press), 178.
12. Levinas, *The Levinas Reader*, 114. Levinas furthers to argue in terms of the praxis of freedom that 'it is a matter of an exigency coming from the other, beyond what is available in my powers, to open an unlimited "deficit", in which the self spends itself without counting, freely', 114–115. Freedom in view of deficit is something that instigates one to turn to what is beyond my mechanism, that is not–I.
13. This image is used in Charles Williams's *The Great Trumps*, which presumably Murdoch had read, perhaps on MacKinnon's recommendation.
14. See Wilson, A.N. *Iris Murdoch As I Knew Her* (London: Hutchinson), 75, 77–8; Peter Conradi, *Iris Murdoch: A Life* (London: Harper Collins, 2001), 255–8.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).